

AGE – new curriculum

Topic overview

- Childhood in Zimbabwe and other societies
 - Youth
 - Old age
 - Perspectives on age
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❖ INTRODUCTION

The topic examines the sociology of age and the life course. Human life is often divided into age spans like childhood, adolescence, youths, adulthood and old age. While aging, itself, is a biological process, what it means to be “old” or “young” and at what ages such distinctions are made varies by culture.

“What age is ‘too young’ and what age is ‘old enough’?”

- Chronological, psychological and social age – the social construction of age
 - Age refers to the time elapsed since an individual was born, known as chronological age.
 - Ideas of age and aging are often seen in biological and psychological terms. There are distinct phases of psychological development which correspond to biological aging.
 - Sociologists argue that the concept of age cannot be fully understood without reference to the social context. From this perspective age can be seen as a social construction. Giddens argues that sociologists should analyse age in terms of social age rather than chronological or biological age.
 - Social age refers to the ‘the norms, values, and roles that are culturally associated with a particular chronological age.’
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❖ CHILDHOOD IN ZIMBABWE AND OTHER SOCIETIES

- Characteristics of childhood

As one considers characteristics of children, there is need to recognise that every child is unique and special in its own way. There are, however, some common characteristics of the period of childhood.

- Vulnerability – being more easily physically, emotionally or mentally hurt, influenced or attacked.
 - Resilience – the process of adapting well in the face of adversity, trauma, tragedy, threats or significant sources of stress.
 - Socialisation– A period characterised by initial or primary socialisation.
 - Dependency – Children are depended on adults (parents, teachers and guardians) both for care and protection from the corrupting world of adults e.g. children are not ‘full persons who make their own decisions and responsibility for their actions.
 - Innocence – They are seen as innocent and easy to corrupt.
 - Physical and mental immaturity – they have not yet developed the complex and sophisticated ways of acting and interacting with one another used by adults. Childhood is seen as incomplete persons e.g. children are irresponsible, childish etc.
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 - Childhood problems and possible solutions
 - Child trafficking. Government must intensify human trafficking awareness campaigns to curb the practice.
 - Child labour
 - Victims of various forms of child abuse (sexual, emotional, physical etc.). Measures deterrent enough must be put in place by the law enforcement agencies to curb this practice.
 - Violation of children rights e.g. entitlements to shelter, education etc.
 - Marginalisation of children e.g. their views are not taken seriously,
 - Policies on children’s welfare in Zimbabwe
 - UNICEF
 - BEAM
 - Education Act
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❖ YOUTH

- Pilcher (1995) claims that youth are seen both in terms of their past – they are no longer children – and their future – they have not yet become adults. She therefore says that “youth is best understood as a stage of transition”.
- It is associated with biological changes of puberty – a universal biological phenomenon involving such changes as the development of secondary sex characteristics, the development of reproductive organs , rapid skeletal growth etc. between childhood and adulthood.
- In Zimbabwe, youth are defined as persons between 15 and 35 years of age. This age range is stipulated in the constitution of Zimbabwe and is in line with the continental definition of youth as defined in the African Youth Charter
- The nature of youth culture

- Youth culture is the way adolescents live, and the norms, values and practices they share. Elements of youth culture include beliefs, behaviours, styles and interests. An emphasis on clothes, popular music, sports, vocabulary, and dating set adolescents apart from the other age groups, giving them what many believe is a distinct culture of their own.
- Youth culture involves a degree of rebellion against parental discipline, which can cause conflict between the generations.
- Adolescents put much emphasis on establishing their independence and on personal attractiveness.
- Adults have worried that youth subcultures are the root of moral degradation and changing values in younger generations.
- ✚ Emergence of youth culture is attributed to:
 - The beginning of compulsory schooling – Coleman argues that age segregation is the root of a separate youth culture. Before compulsory schooling many children and adolescents interacted with adults. Modern children interact with their peers which allows them to develop shared experiences and meanings, which are the root of youth culture.

- Problems faced by the youth in Zimbabwe

- Engaging in juvenile delinquency e.g. alcohol and drug abuse
- High rate of unemployment – in Zimbabwe unemployment has become one of the most pervasive challenges faced by young people due to socioeconomic and political collapse that characterised the past decades.
- Peer pressure
- Lack of capital to start projects – many young people have responded to the unavailability of jobs by starting up their entrepreneurial businesses in various sectors like tourism, agriculture, mining, , IT etc. however, these young face a variety of constraints that hinder the growth and development of their enterprises e.g. limited access to start-up investment capital. Mateta Patience (2017) analysed the challenges faced by the youth in accessing the Zimbabwean youth empowerment fund taking Mutare district as her case study.
- Teenage and unwanted pregnancies and unsafe abortions
- Early marriages – due to economic hardships, religious beliefs etc.
- Youths living with HIV – although HIV prevalence rates in Zimbabwe are on the decline, HIV and AIDS among youth is still one of the major health , social, economic development and human rights problems in the country. Young people and notably girls and young women remain the biggest sector at risk of new infection.
- Out-of-school youth – there is a growing problem of youth who drop out of school.

- Government policies on youth empowerment

The Zimbabwean government put various legal frameworks in a bid to deal with the economic, social and political problems facing the youth in Zimbabwe.

- ✚ National youth policy of 2000

- The national youth policy was developed in 2000 (and revised in 2013) to provide an enabling framework for the development and empowerment of youth.

- ✚ Youth fund schemes aimed at curbing unemployment in the country e.g. the Kurera/Ukondla youth fund which was launched by the government to enable youth to start their own businesses
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❖ OLD AGE

- Just as there are no clear definitions of childhood or youth, there are no clear definitions of the age at which adulthood ends and later life begins. The social definition of old age varies from society to society. For example, in Europe preindustrial revolution old age began when people became 'helpless and dependent' rather than when they had lived for a particular number of years (Pilcher, 1995; Featherstone and Hepworth, 1990). However, modern societies see retirement from employment and or eligibility for a state pension as defining old age.
- Old age refers to ages nearing or surpassing the life expectancy of human beings and is thus the end of the human life cycle.
- According to HelpAge, an organisation catering for the needs of the senior citizens, older people in Zimbabwe estimated to be 760 000 or 6% of the population.
- Gerontology
 - Gerontology is the study of the social, cultural, psychological, cognitive and biological aspects of ageing. The word was coined by Ilya Ilyich Mechnikov in 1903.
 - It is the scientific study of old age, the process of ageing, and the particular problems of old people.
- Problems of old age

Growing old can bring on various problems as our bodies change. Industrial societies do bring problems for the elderly:

 - Structural Isolation, loneliness and depression – children tend to focus more on their marriage partners and their own children.
 - Often characterised by material deprivation i.e. the elderly are more likely to be poor than other social groups in the population, especially women and those from the working class. Low pay and part time work during their working lives may have restricted their entitlement to pensions. For example, in Zimbabwe, since the turn of the new millennium the value of state pensions has declined relative to average wages, making relative poverty more likely for those dependent on the state for an income after retirement.
 - Old age stereotyping – Butler (1969) defined ageism as a process of negative stereotyping and discrimination against people purely on their chronological age.

Stereotypes and the media all serve to make old age appear similar to childhood i.e. old age is “*infantilized*” and *dehumanised*, as a result they lose the status of being adults who have full personhood. Most set ups at old people’s homes stereotype the elderly (Hockey, 1993 study of old people’s homes). For example they are not allowed to keep their own money, they are not expected to be sexually active. In most African societies the elderly are believed to be associated with issues of witchcraft.

- Poor facilities, service provision and care e.g. lobbyists for the care of the elderly say lack of food, shelter, clothing, drugs and other basic amenities are now widespread in most old age homes.
- Violence and abuse especially older women e.g. sexual, emotional and physical abuse.
- Old age health problems – getting older can bring on health problems as our bodies change e.g. Dementia (memory loss), stroke, poor vision, hearing impairment, high blood cholesterol, arthritis (slow breakdown of cartilage and bone), obesity, hypertension, diabetes and skin problems.
- Parsons noted that the elderly have less status in most societies e.g. in the US. Once children have grown up and men have retired, the elderly lose their most important social roles.

- Policies which cater for old age in Zimbabwe

The Zimbabwean government has not turned a blind eye to the plight of the aged.

- In 2012, the Older Persons bill was signed into law – it aims at paving way for selected social protection mechanisms and an older persons fund to be set aside for such purposes as well as addressing other emerging issues affecting senior citizens in Zimbabwe. However, there has been little government budget allocation to implement the law due to fiscal constraints faced by the country.
- Supplying the elderly with farming inputs in the rural areas.
- Pension pay-outs for the elderly.
- In most government institutions the elderly (above 60 years) are given first priority in service delivery e.g.at hospitals.

🚩 *Assess the effectiveness of the old age policies in addressing the challenges faced by the elderly in Zimbabwe:*

- In neighbouring countries, like South Africa, with more than three million elderly people, the elderly rely on old age grants given by the government to 60 years and above, which is non-existent in Zimbabwe.
- Fiscal challenges by the government pose a serious threat to the welfare of the elderly as the government fail to support the elderly in society.
- Policies fail to eradicate stereotypical beliefs held against the elderly in society.
- Pension pay-outs paid by the government to the elderly are little to cushion them against the economic hardships befitting the country.

- Volunteerism

- The need to volunteer to care for the aged.

- The concept of ‘old people’s homes’

✚ Examples of old people's homes in Zimbabwe

- According to the Herald of April 19, 2017, Zimbabwe has 166 registered elderly homes.

- The best Old Age homes in Zimbabwe 2018 include:

✚ Mucheke Old People's home – Masvingo

✚ Idawekwako Old Aged home – Marondera

✚ Bako redonhodzo old peoples home – Highfield, Harare.

✚ Amaveni Old people's home – Kwekwe

✚ Darby and Joan centre for the Aged – Belvedere, Harare.

✚ Pioneer Lodge home for the Aged – Masvingo

✚ S.o.d.a Society for the destitute aged – Harare.

✚ Dandaro – Borrowdale, Harare.

✚ Why do some children send their parents to old age homes?

It is believed that not only are old people sent, many are willingly going to such homes.

Reasons include:

- a. To avoid responsibility of caring for a terminally sick parent who needs nurse care (will a mother send her terminally child away?)
- b. Children going abroad because of jobs, transfers and better prospects for children's future and better life.
- c. To avoid constant clash of views of the old and the younger generations.
- d. To live comfortably in nuclear families
- e. To have freedom of movement, travel and other enjoyments.
- f. Selfishness rules everything, there is no love, respect, tolerance, empathy towards elders.

✚ What are the advantages and disadvantages of sending your parent to an old people's home?

Benefits of Elder Home Care Services

- a. Home care services are time consuming – it becomes difficult for the caregiver to be able to juggle the time needed.
- b. Home caregivers have the necessary experience and training for the specific job.

Drawbacks of living in a care home

- a. Care homes can be very costly
- b. There may be limited choices of homes with a vacancy for your relative, depending on his/her circumstances
- c. Unfamiliar surroundings
- d. Loneliness and loss of contact with neighbours and old friends

- e. Families can feel guilty that they are not looking after their relative themselves, even though this may no longer be practical.

Conclusion on old people's homes

Overall elder care homes are beneficial because of the proper care that they serve their clients.

❖ PERSPECTIVES ON AGE

• Theoretical views on age

✚ Functionalist perspective on age

a) Age and the social system – Parsons.

- Parsons related age differences to the overall functioning of the social system.
- He believed that differences in the social roles associated with age groups (childhood, adolescence and old age) were vital for the smooth functioning of society. However, tensions between age groups can be found.
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✚ Conflict perspective on age

a) The political economy of old age

- It sees age as another aspect of stratification along with social class, ethnicity, gender etc. which lead to inequality.
- Conflict approaches have developed the 'political economy of old age' which explores the relationship between the labour market, government policy and social class. For Townsend studied the link between old age, poverty and social class arguing that inadequate state pensions lead to poverty among those from lower class backgrounds. During their working lives these people have too little income to save for retirement.

b) Age and differentiation (Vincent, 1995;2006)

- Age is an important way of differentiating people in in all societies. It is a form of stratification, a source of inequality and potentially a source of exploitation, conflict and discrimination.
- Age differentiation can shape life chances and causes divisions.

✚ Interpretivist perspective of age

a) Social construction of age

- Age cannot be understood in scientific terms, but in its social context. Age categories are a social construct – a product of social definitions, not natural, biological categories.
- Interpretivists place particular emphasis upon meanings attached to categories such as childhood, youth or old age and the effects that those meanings have.

b) Growing up and old – hockey and James (1993)

- The meaning of old age is linked to the meaning of childhood e.g. their studies of old people's homes show that the elderly are often compared to children and treated as if they were children – e.g. "*infantilised old age*"

Evaluation

- It provides an interesting discussion of the way in which childhood and old age are linked through the process of infantilization.
- Interpretivist approaches are often accused of ignoring inequality and social structure.

Feminist perspective on age.

- Like conflict perspectives, feminists emphasize the relationship between inequality and age – gender inequality.
- a) Feminism and childhood – Oakley (1994)
 - Oakley argues that there are many similarities between the position of women and the position of children in society. In the 19th century the positions were the same. Since then the position of women has improved, but the position of children has not as they are still disadvantaged compared to other social groups.
 - Women and children are members of minority groups and lack their rights.
- b) Women and aging – Gannon
 - Gannon examines myths about the differences in the process of aging for men and women. Instead of emanating from biological differences, aging differences are a result of “lifestyles, habits, expectations and roles that place women at risk” e.g. they have more caring responsibilities.

Labelling theory (Ray et al 2006)

- The elderly can be negatively affected by exposure to stereotypical labels and experiences of ageism e.g. the use of infantilised language or ‘baby talk’ and linguistic expression of pity (particularly from medical professionals) cause older people to accept the inference that they are no longer independent adults causing them to behave in a passive and dependent manner and think that they are helpless.

Post-modernist theory

- Postmodernists such as Blaikie (1999) argue that chronological age, ageism and age – determined inequality are less likely to shape people’s life experiences in the 21st century. For example, social class plays a great part in determining people’s level of income in old age.

- Conclusion

- It is difficult to generalise about people’s experiences of age as they vary according to other aspects of stratification such as class, gender and ethnicity. Theories of age which fail to take this into account can never be wholly convincing.